

French onion Soup with caraway and Gruyère cheese

This soup is not only as good as the classic that's made with beef stock, it's better. Sweet, savory, complex—the **buttery** flavors melt in your mouth. Roasted Vegetable Stock (page 46) is important to this recipe; it adds a rich color and taste and is well worth the effort. If you have a mandoline, use it to slice your onions paper thin.

3 pounds sweet yellow onions (such as Vidalia), very thinly sliced

2 tablespoons olive oil

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1 tablespoon caraway seeds

½ cup port wine [125ml]

2 tablespoons dark red miso

4½ cups Roasted Vegetable Stock (page 46), kept at a simmer [1.15L]

1 cup grated Swiss Gruyère cheese [80g]

4 slices of Italian or other rustic bread, thickly sliced and lightly toasted

1. In large heavy-bottomed pot, **cook** the onions in the olive oil over medium heat, covered, for 5 minutes. Uncover and cook, stirring occasionally, until the onions are very brown and soft, 35 to 40 minutes longer. Don't rush them; this is the key to this soup: onions that have become tender and sweet, not burned or bitter. Season lightly with salt and pepper.
2. Add the caraway seeds and cook, stirring, for a few seconds. **Pour** in the port and bring to a simmer. With a wooden spoon, scrape up all the caramelized onion bits stuck to the bottom of the pot so they can dissolve in the liquid. Continue to cook, stirring often, until most of the liquid is evaporated and you are left with a pot of glazed caramelized onions.
3. Put the miso in a small bowl and stir in about ½ cup [125ml] of the stock. **Stir** until the paste is completely incorporated into the liquid. Add to the onions and sim-

mer until the liquid is reduced by half. Add the remaining stock and simmer for 15 minutes.

4. Preheat the oven to 400°F [200°C]. Place 4 ovenproof bowls on a baking sheet. **Pour** about 1 cup [250ml] of soup into each bowl, leaving room on top for cheese and bread. Add 2 tablespoons of the grated cheese to each bowl, then a bread slice. If the bread is too big for the bowl, cut it into 3 smaller pieces and wedge them in. Top with 2 more tablespoons cheese. Bake for 10 minutes, or until the cheese is browned and bubbly. Serve piping hot.

SERVES 4

